The Emerging Markets Expansion Playbook

28 country scorecards, the 3-Door Expansion System™, and the engagement ladder behind them — compiled from sipiteno.com.

Sipiteno · Larnaca, Cyprus · sipiteno.com

1. Your product is not the problem

If your tech company has stalled trying to enter Eastern Europe, the Caucasus, or Central Asia — it is not your product, your price, or your team. You are missing the three things that actually open markets: **the right introductions, a regulatory map, and a local team that ships fast.**

Every market in this playbook is entered the same way, through three doors:

Door	What it is	Why it matters
1. Warm Introductions	Handoffs from people already trusted inside the market	The difference between a 1% cold reply rate and a 47% warm one
2. Regulatory Map	Which licenses, data rules and compliance traps kill deals	15 years of scar tissue, codified
3. Local Execution	Bilingual teams who close in weeks, not quarters	The team that shows up

2. Why entries stall in month three

The usual pattern: a company researches, picks a country, translates the site, hires a local contractor, and waits. Three months later there is no pipeline and the conclusion is “that market is not ready”. The market was ready. The introduction was missing.

Across these 28 markets, very little moves through cold outreach. Deals move through someone who already holds the relationship and will lend it to you. That is the actual distribution channel, and it is invisible from a spreadsheet in another country.

Three assumptions that don't travel

“Good product, market finds it.” Inbound assumes a search-and-review culture. Where buyers ask a peer instead, being findable buys little.

“We'll localise later.” Localisation is not translation. It is an invoice their finance team accepts, contract terms their lawyer has seen, and a support hour overlapping their day.

“One regional hire covers it.” These are 28 distinct regulatory and relationship environments, not one region.

The order that works

1. Pick on evidence — regulatory friction, payment rails, language load, and whether you have any warm path in at all.

2. Get one warm introduction before you build anything. One real buyer conversation rewrites more assumptions than a quarter of desk research.

3. Fix invoicing and contracting next. Unglamorous, and the most common place a nearly-closed deal dies.

4. Only then localise the funnel — now you know which objections to answer.
5. Hire in-market last, once you know what the role actually does.

3. The 28 country scorecards

Compiled from Sipiteno's published market-entry research (sipiteno.com/locations). Capital, tech hub, languages, key industries, typical timeline and engagement size for every market in this playbook.

SOUTHEAST EUROPE

Growing tech ecosystems around capital-city technology parks, competitive costs, and EU-oriented regulatory trajectories in most markets.

Albania	
Hub	Tirana (Tirana Tech Park)
Languages	Albanian, English, Italian
Industries	Tourism, Energy, IT Outsourcing, Agriculture
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Albania sits in Southeast Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Tirana Tech Park in Tirana. Key industries include Tourism, Energy, IT Outsourcing, Agriculture. For B2B technology companies, Albania represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

CAUCASUS

Strategic crossroads between Europe and Asia, low-friction business registration, and governments actively courting technology companies.

Armenia	
Hub	Yerevan (Yerevan IT Park)
Languages	Armenian, Russian, English
Industries	IT & Software, Mining, Agriculture
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Armenia sits in Caucasus, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Yerevan IT Park in Yerevan. Key industries include IT & Software, Mining, Agriculture. For B2B technology companies, Armenia represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

Azerbaijan	
Hub	Baku (Baku IT Park)
Languages	Azerbaijani, Russian, English
Industries	Oil & Gas, Transport, ICT
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Azerbaijan sits in Caucasus, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Baku IT Park in Baku. Key industries include Oil & Gas, Transport, ICT. For B2B technology companies, Azerbaijan represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

SOUTHEAST EUROPE

Growing tech ecosystems around capital-city technology parks, competitive costs, and EU-oriented regulatory trajectories in most markets.

Bosnia and Herzegovina	
Hub	Sarajevo (Sarajevo Technology Park)
Languages	Bosnian, Croatian, Serbian, English
Industries	Energy, Manufacturing, IT Services
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Bosnia and Herzegovina sits in Southeast Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Sarajevo Technology Park in Sarajevo. Key industries include Energy, Manufacturing, IT Services. For B2B technology companies, Bosnia and Herzegovina represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

Bulgaria	
Hub	Sofia (Sofia Tech Park)
Languages	Bulgarian, English
Industries	IT Outsourcing, Manufacturing, Tourism
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Bulgaria sits in Southeast Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Sofia Tech Park in Sofia. Key industries include IT Outsourcing, Manufacturing, Tourism. For B2B technology companies, Bulgaria represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

Croatia	
Hub	Zagreb (Zagreb Technology Park)
Languages	Croatian, English, German
Industries	Tourism, IT Services, Pharma
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Croatia sits in Southeast Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Zagreb Technology Park in Zagreb. Key industries include Tourism, IT Services, Pharma. For B2B technology companies, Croatia represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

MEDITERRANEAN

An EU jurisdiction with an established tech-company registry regime, English-language business culture, and a bridge between EU and Middle East clients.

Cyprus	
Hub	Nicosia (Nicosia Innovation Center)
Languages	Greek, English, Turkish, Russian
Industries	Financial Services, Tourism, ICT
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Cyprus sits in Mediterranean, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Nicosia Innovation Center in Nicosia. Key industries include Financial Services, Tourism, ICT. For B2B technology companies, Cyprus represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

CENTRAL EUROPE

Lower operating costs than Western Europe, EU membership or alignment, strong IT outsourcing bases, and talent pipelines that scale beyond the local market.

Czech Republic	
Hub	Prague (Prague Innovation Center)
Languages	Czech, English, German
Industries	Automotive, IT & Software, Engineering
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Czech Republic sits in Central Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Prague Innovation Center in Prague. Key industries include Automotive, IT & Software, Engineering. For B2B technology companies, Czech Republic represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

NORTHERN EUROPE

Advanced digital government, e-residency regimes, and the region's highest willingness to transact fully remotely.

Estonia	
Hub	Tallinn (Tallinn Tehnopol)
Languages	Estonian, English, Russian
Industries	Digital Government, Cybersecurity, Fintech
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Estonia sits in Northern Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Tallinn Tehnopol in Tallinn. Key industries include Digital Government, Cybersecurity, Fintech. For B2B technology companies, Estonia represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

EAST AFRICA

One of the world's youngest populations, mobile-first consumers, and governments prioritising digital infrastructure.

Ethiopia	
Hub	Addis Ababa (Addis Ababa Innovation Hub)
Languages	Amharic, English
Industries	Agriculture, Manufacturing, ICT
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Ethiopia sits in East Africa, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Addis Ababa Innovation Hub in Addis Ababa. Key industries include Agriculture, Manufacturing, ICT. For B2B technology companies, Ethiopia represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

CAUCASUS

Strategic crossroads between Europe and Asia, low-friction business registration, and governments actively courting technology companies.

Georgia	
Hub	Tbilisi (Tbilisi Tech Park)
Languages	Georgian, English, Russian
Industries	Tourism, Agriculture, ICT
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Georgia sits in Caucasus, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Tbilisi Tech Park in Tbilisi. Key industries include Tourism, Agriculture, ICT. For B2B technology companies, Georgia represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

SOUTHEAST EUROPE

Growing tech ecosystems around capital-city technology parks, competitive costs, and EU-oriented regulatory trajectories in most markets.

Greece	
Hub	Athens (Athens Science & Technology Park)
Languages	Greek, English
Industries	Tourism, Shipping, ICT
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Greece sits in Southeast Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Athens Science & Technology Park in Athens. Key industries include Tourism, Shipping, ICT. For B2B technology companies, Greece represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

CENTRAL EUROPE

Lower operating costs than Western Europe, EU membership or alignment, strong IT outsourcing bases, and talent pipelines that scale beyond the local market.

Hungary	
Hub	Budapest (Budapest Science Park)
Languages	Hungarian, English, German
Industries	Automotive, Pharma, ICT
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Hungary sits in Central Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Budapest Science Park in Budapest. Key industries include Automotive, Pharma, ICT. For B2B technology companies, Hungary represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

SOUTH ASIA

The largest absolute talent pool in this playbook and a domestic market where localized B2B software still beats global incumbents.

India	
Hub	New Delhi (Bengaluru - India's Silicon Valley)
Languages	Hindi, English, Tamil, Telugu
Industries	IT Services, Software, Manufacturing
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

India sits in South Asia, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Bengaluru - India's Silicon Valley in New Delhi. Key industries include IT Services, Software, Manufacturing. For B2B technology companies, India represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

CENTRAL ASIA

The least saturated region in this playbook: fast-growing domestic demand, IT-park visa and tax regimes for tech employers, and almost no Western competition.

Kazakhstan	
Hub	Astana (Astana Hub)
Languages	Kazakh, Russian, English
Industries	Oil & Gas, Mining, ICT
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Kazakhstan sits in Central Asia, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Astana Hub in Astana. Key industries include Oil & Gas, Mining, ICT. For B2B technology companies, Kazakhstan represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

Kyrgyzstan	
Hub	Bishkek (Bishkek IT Park)
Languages	Kyrgyz, Russian, English
Industries	Agriculture, Mining, ICT
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Kyrgyzstan sits in Central Asia, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Bishkek IT Park in Bishkek. Key industries include Agriculture, Mining, ICT. For B2B technology companies, Kyrgyzstan represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

NORTHERN EUROPE

Advanced digital government, e-residency regimes, and the region's highest willingness to transact fully remotely.

Latvia	
Hub	Riga (Riga TechHub)
Languages	Latvian, English, Russian
Industries	IT Services, Fintech, Logistics
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Latvia sits in Northern Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Riga TechHub in Riga. Key industries include IT Services, Fintech, Logistics. For B2B technology companies, Latvia represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

Lithuania	
Hub	Vilnius (Vilnius Tech Park)
Languages	Lithuanian, English, Russian
Industries	Fintech, IT Services, Biotech
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Lithuania sits in Northern Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Vilnius Tech Park in Vilnius. Key industries include Fintech, IT Services, Biotech. For B2B technology companies, Lithuania represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

EASTERN EUROPE

Deep engineering talent pools, cost-competitive delivery, and time-zone overlap with both EU and Gulf markets.

Moldova	
Hub	Chisinau (Chisinau IT Park)
Languages	Romanian, Russian, English
Industries	Agriculture, IT Services, Manufacturing
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Moldova sits in Eastern Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Chisinau IT Park in Chisinau. Key industries include Agriculture, IT Services, Manufacturing. For B2B technology companies, Moldova represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

SOUTHEAST EUROPE

Growing tech ecosystems around capital-city technology parks, competitive costs, and EU-oriented regulatory trajectories in most markets.

Montenegro	
Hub	Podgorica (Podgorica Technology Park)
Languages	Montenegrin, Serbian, English
Industries	Tourism, Energy, ICT
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Montenegro sits in Southeast Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Podgorica Technology Park in Podgorica. Key industries include Tourism, Energy, ICT. For B2B technology companies, Montenegro represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

North Macedonia	
Hub	Skopje (Skopje Tech Park)
Languages	Macedonian, Albanian, English
Industries	Manufacturing, IT Services, Agriculture
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

North Macedonia sits in Southeast Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Skopje Tech Park in Skopje. Key industries include Manufacturing, IT Services, Agriculture. For B2B technology companies, North Macedonia represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

CENTRAL EUROPE

Lower operating costs than Western Europe, EU membership or alignment, strong IT outsourcing bases, and talent pipelines that scale beyond the local market.

Poland	
Hub	Warsaw (Warsaw Business Hub & Krakow Tech Park)
Languages	Polish, English, German
Industries	IT Outsourcing, Fintech, Gaming
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Poland sits in Central Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Warsaw Business Hub & Krakow Tech Park in Warsaw. Key industries include IT Outsourcing, Fintech, Gaming. For B2B technology companies, Poland represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

SOUTHEAST EUROPE

Growing tech ecosystems around capital-city technology parks, competitive costs, and EU-oriented regulatory trajectories in most markets.

Romania	
Hub	Bucharest (Bucharest Tech Hub & Cluj Innovation Park)
Languages	Romanian, English, French
Industries	IT Outsourcing, Automotive, Manufacturing
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Romania sits in Southeast Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Bucharest Tech Hub & Cluj Innovation Park in Bucharest. Key industries include IT Outsourcing, Automotive, Manufacturing. For B2B technology companies, Romania represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

Serbia	
Hub	Belgrade (Belgrade Science & Technology Park)
Languages	Serbian, English, Russian
Industries	IT Services, Agriculture, Manufacturing
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Serbia sits in Southeast Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Belgrade Science & Technology Park in Belgrade. Key industries include IT Services, Agriculture, Manufacturing. For B2B technology companies, Serbia represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

CENTRAL EUROPE

Lower operating costs than Western Europe, EU membership or alignment, strong IT outsourcing bases, and talent pipelines that scale beyond the local market.

Slovakia	
Hub	Bratislava (Bratislava Technology Park)
Languages	Slovak, English, German
Industries	Automotive, IT Services, Manufacturing
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Slovakia sits in Central Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Bratislava Technology Park in Bratislava. Key industries include Automotive, IT Services, Manufacturing. For B2B technology companies, Slovakia represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

Slovenia	
Hub	Ljubljana (Ljubljana Technology Park)
Languages	Slovenian, English, German
Industries	Manufacturing, Pharma, ICT
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Slovenia sits in Central Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Ljubljana Technology Park in Ljubljana. Key industries include Manufacturing, Pharma, ICT. For B2B technology companies, Slovenia represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

EASTERN EUROPE

Deep engineering talent pools, cost-competitive delivery, and time-zone overlap with both EU and Gulf markets.

Ukraine	
Hub	Kyiv (Kyiv Tech Hub & Lviv IT Park)
Languages	Ukrainian, Russian, English
Industries	IT Outsourcing, Agriculture, Defense Tech
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Ukraine sits in Eastern Europe, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Kyiv Tech Hub & Lviv IT Park in Kyiv. Key industries include IT Outsourcing, Agriculture, Defense Tech. For B2B technology companies, Ukraine represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

CENTRAL ASIA

The least saturated region in this playbook: fast-growing domestic demand, IT-park visa and tax regimes for tech employers, and almost no Western competition.

Uzbekistan	
Hub	Tashkent (Tashkent IT Park)
Languages	Uzbek, Russian, English
Industries	ICT, Textiles, Agriculture
Timeline	12-16 weeks
Engagement	$15,000-$100,000+

Uzbekistan sits in Central Asia, offering strategic access to regional markets. The technology ecosystem centers on Tashkent IT Park in Tashkent. Key industries include ICT, Textiles, Agriculture. For B2B technology companies, Uzbekistan represents an opportunity to establish a regional foothold with lower operational costs than Western European markets while maintaining quality talent pipelines.

4. How to work with Sipiteno

Five ways to engage, climbing in value. Start free, scale when ready.

Rung	What	Price
1	Expansion Playbook (this document)	Free
2	30-minute strategy scoping call with a written action plan	Free
3	MicroSaaS MVP build — design, full-stack, deploy, 30-day monitoring, 4-8 weeks	$15,000-$50,000 fixed
4	Business development retainer — 10-30 qualified leads/month, partnerships, market intelligence	$3,000-$10,000/month
5	AI implementation program — assessment, MVP build, deployment by our engineers	$25,000-$100,000+

Every engagement starts with a free 30-minute scoping call. Every engagement includes a regulatory map for your target markets. If we do not open at least one qualified market opportunity within 90 days of kickoff, the next quarter of work is on us.

Source notes: country data reflects sipiteno.com's published location scorecards at time of generation. Timelines and engagement sizes are typical ranges, not quotes. This playbook is informational and does not constitute legal or tax advice.

Get in touch: sales@sipiteno.com · sipiteno.com · +357-24-628166